ART/ BOOKS

In His Own Image

*Artist **Waswo X. Waswo's** new book is typically opulent, playful and self-absorbed*





A COLLECTIVE (from top, left) 'Dalpat Jingar's Workshop', by Chirag Kumawat; 'Chai' by WXW and Rajesh Soni; 'When Searching is not Finding', by WXW, Vijay, Dalpat Jingar and Shankar Kumawat

Karkhana is a sumptuously produced coffee-table book, replete with reproductions of the artworks produced by Waswo X. Waswo (WXW) and his team in Udaipur over the past decade or so. For those unfamiliar with WXW's work, the book is a comprehensive introduction to the American artist's immersion into the traditions of Rajasthani miniature painting. Those who already know his oeuvre will recognise the typical mix of studio photography, hand-painted photographs and miniature painting for which WXW is now known.

Along with the various series of works, WXW writes a light and engaging diary of his daily life in Udaipur. Explaining that his practice is rooted in collective effort, WXW also stresses that it is *his* vision the team works to render. As we follow the daily routines, we see the different kinds of work: the conception, possibly the photography (though not all the images have a photo element), the actual execution of a painting, with different highly skilled artists responsible for different parts (one for the figures, one for the flora

ART/ BOOKS

State of the Art

NO EXPLORATION OF MODERN AND CONTEMPORARY INDIAN ART CAN BE EXHAUSTIVE, BUT **MORTIMER CHATTERJEE'S** NEW COMPENDIUM IS CERTAINLY EXPANSIVE

Turning page after page of *Moving Focus*, a compendium on Indian art edited by Mumbai gallerist Mortimer Chatterjee, one hopes that there would be a parallel universe in which the two volumes would serve as guidebooks for an actual public collection of art in India, made since 1900, which we would be able to experience together in all its eclectic, idiosyncratic and cacophonous expansiveness.

To make *Moving Focus*, Chatterjee invited 54 artists, curators, historians and writers to each nominate five artworks made by artists living in India or identifying as part of its diaspora. In the overall selection, there are, of course, a lot of paintings, some sculptures, photography, installations and new media art, a fair number of them recognisable and iconic, but also unexpected objects like Dashrath Patel's in-flight serveware from 1968, and Dilip Chowdhury's cover for *Design* magazine from 1964.

While *Moving Focus* could have easily been just a canon-building exercise, the openness of Chatterjee's invitation allowed the contributors to make both personal and political arguments for each of their choices. The explanations that accompany the art then not only familiarise readers with the significance of the work at hand but also with the inspirations, preoccupations, and obsessions of the nominators themselves. When artist Atul Dodiya introduces us to his mentor and friend Bhupen Khakhar's *Ranchodbhai Relaxing in Bed* (1977) by recalling the moment when he first encountered the painting at Mumbai's Jehangir Art Gallery,



Courtesy: VIVAN SUNDARAM

JOINT ART 'Burial-Coffin' by Vivan Sundaram, 1993; and (right) 'Is It What You Think?', 1998, by Rummana Hussain